UNIT 3: EXPLORING CAREERS

TOPIC 4: EXPLORING CAREERS THROUGH INFORMATIONAL INTERVIEWS AND JOB SHADOWS

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand the importance of asking the right questions
- Understand the purpose of an informational interview
- Understand the benefits of a job shadow

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Practice asking informational interview questions
- Identify three businesses/agencies to contact for a job shadow and/or informational interview

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Opening Activity
The One Question Ice Breaker

Materials: Situations written on small slips of paper

Time: 15 minutes

If you could ask just one question to discover a person's/provider's suitability for .....X..... (insert situation, see examples below), what would your question be?

Pair people up to work on creating the one question they would ask and have them pick one of the situations without looking.

Examples of situations to use for the activity and insert in the instruction:

- baby-sitting or child-minding
- being a street worker/youth worker
- running a business together
- arranging your charity bungee jump/parachute leap/sky-dive
- being your personal assistant/bodyguard
- being your boss/employer/leader
- being the leader of your country/company
- being a judge
- being the commissioner of DYS

Give students a time limit to create their question. At the end of the time limit, ask the students to share their question as well as to talk about the process they went through to choose their question. They might also want to share other questions they considered.

There are no absolute 'right' or best questions — there are many effective questions, depending on the situation and people's needs, but there are certainly questions which do not work well and which should be avoided.

Discussion Questions:

- Are there advantages in preparing important questions, rather than relying on instinct or invention at the time?
- What else happens while we ask questions, aside from the words between us? (Explore body language and non-verbal communications.)
- What sort of questions are least effective and should be avoided? (Try to identify characteristics of ineffective questions.)
- What sort of questions are most effective? (Try to identify characteristics of effective questions.)
- How do we feel when being asked effective/ineffective questions?
- To what extent and how should questions be tailored for the particular listener, and for the questioner's needs?
- What crucial questions do we ask (at work/in life) which we could prepare more carefully?

Adapted from http://www.businessballs.com/freeteambuildingactivities.htm#team-building-games-exercises-activities
April 13, 2010

Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students will understand the definition and purpose of informational interviews and job shadows.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Definitions of Informational Interview and Job Shadow

- Ask students what additional information would be helpful to have in deciding where he/she might want to work or what career field she/he might want to work within.
- What are the different ways people find out about jobs, careers, organizations and businesses?
- Two ways to find out more about a job, career, business or organization are through Informational Interviews and Job Shadows.

Informational Interview
Definition: "An informational interview is an interview conducted to collect information about a job, career field, industry or company? It is an interview with an individual working in a career you would like to learn more about."
From http://jobsearch.about.com/od/infointerviews/g/infointerview.htm April 14, 2010

Job Shadow
Definition: "An experience that takes place at a work site in which an individual observes and interacts with an employee to learn about a specific job. As an exploratory exercise, teachers (employers and workers) share first-hand knowledge about occupations and businesses in their region. The individual gains real life experience, which may lead them to improved career choice decisions. Job shadowing is also being used as part of the interview process by some employers."
From http://www.vtlmi.info/glossary.cfm#J April 14, 2010

Activity: Practicing Informational Interviews

Objectives:
- Students will learn to choose questions for an informational interview.
- Students will practice asking informational interview questions.

Time: 25 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"Questions to Ask at the Informational Interview,"** pens/pencils, and paper, stopwatch

Option One: Invite professional men and women from a variety of career fields to come practice informational interviews with the young people. Hand out **"Questions to Ask at the Informational Interview"** and ask students to choose 5-7 questions from the list. Match students up with the professional guests (if possible with people from career fields in which they are interested) to practice informational interviews. You might need to match up a couple of students with each guest. Ask the guests to provide feedback to the young people in a positive, constructive way at the end of the interview. Discuss with the young people what new information they discovered through the process.

Option Two: Hand out **"Questions to Ask at the Informational Interview"** and explain that students will choose 5-7 questions from the list. After the young people have prepared their interview questions, direct them to move their chairs so they are sitting in two lines. Explain that they will have two minutes with 5 different people to practice asking interview questions (one minute for their question, one minute for their partner's question). Encourage participants to take notes and think of appropriate follow-up questions. At the end of the two minutes, have everyone stand up and move one chair to the right as shown. Continue until everyone has 'interviewed' five different people.

Round One					Round Two				
1	2	3	4	5	6	1	2	3	4
6	7	8	9	10	7	8	9	10	5

Discuss the activity:

- How did it feel to ask the questions?
- Why is it important to really listen? (to know if one of your other questions has already been answered and to see if there are appropriate follow-up questions to ask). How do you show that you are listening?
- Why is it important to take notes?
- Which question do you think was most important? Why?
- What are the benefits of an informational interview?
- The interview should feel like a conversation, not an interrogation.

Job Shadow Discussion/Research

Objective: Students will discuss the benefits of a job shadow experience and identify three jobs they would like to shadow.
Time: 20 minutes
Materials: Flipchart paper, markers, pens/pencils, paper

Ask students what they think the benefits of a job shadow experience might be, and capture what they say on flipchart. (For example: see first hand the ins and outs of the job, experience the workplace culture, see how people interact, experience how busy or boring the job can be, etc.) Have students think about three career fields they would like to shadow. If computers are available, have students look up three area businesses/organizations in their interested career field for potential job shadows or informational interviews. Discuss what they can do to try to set up a job shadow experience. Work with the students, employers and other partners to create job shadow opportunities for students.

Questions to Ask at the Informational Interview

You have arrived and are greeted by the individual at the front desk. When the interviewee comes out to meet you, introduce yourself. Thank your contact for his or her willingness to meet with you, and re-emphasize that you are there to learn and gather information about his or her career field. Use an informal dialogue during the interview.

Below are some typical informational interview questions. Pick the questions that get at what you most want to know.

Questions about Job Duties:

1. What is your job like? What does a typical day look like? What do you do? What are the duties/functions/responsibilities of your job?
2. What kinds of problems do you deal with? What kinds of decisions do you make? What percentage of your time is spent doing what? How does the time use vary? What part of this job do you find most satisfying? Most challenging?

Questions about Experience, Education, Training:

3. How did this type of work interest you and how did you get started?
4. How did you get your job? What jobs and experiences have led you to your present position? What was most helpful? Can you suggest some ways a student could obtain this necessary experience?
5. What are the educational requirements for this job? What other types of credentials or licenses are required? What types of training do companies offer persons entering this field?
6. What are the skills that are most important for a position in this field? What particular skills or talents are most essential to be effective in your job? How did you learn these skills? Did you enter this position through a formal training program? How can I evaluate whether or not I have the necessary skills for a position such as yours?

Questions about the Career Field:

7. What are the various jobs in this career field? What sorts of changes are occurring in this field? How is the economy affecting this industry?
8. What are the typical entry-level job titles and functions? What entry-level jobs are best for learning as much as possible?
9. How does a person progress in your field? What is a typical career path in this field or organization? What are the advancement opportunities?
10. What can you tell me about the employment outlook in your occupational field? How much demand is there for people in this occupation? How rapidly is the field growing? Can you estimate future job openings?
11. If your work were suddenly eliminated, what kinds of work do you feel prepared to do?

Questions about Job Incentives/Satisfaction:

12. What are the salary ranges for various levels in this field? Is there a salary ceiling? What other benefits are typical for this field?
13. What are the major rewards aside from extrinsic rewards such as money, fringe benefits, travel, etc.?
14. If you could do things all over again, would you choose the same path for yourself? Why? What would you change?

Questions about Personal Characteristics:

15. What abilities or personal qualities do you believe contribute most to success in this field/job?
16. These are my strongest assets (skills, areas of knowledge, personality traits and values): _____. Where would they fit in this field? Where might they fit in other fields?

Words of Advice:

17. Do you have any special words of warning or encouragement as a result of your experience?
18. What advice would you give me as I try to figure out my own career path?

Adapted from **http://www.quintcareers.com/information_interview.html** April 14, 2010